Travel Agents: Taiwan — Rules Draft (v3, first-pass outline)

> A skeleton for `bg-developer / bg-elegance` to flesh into the real rulebook. Teach-in-play order. Voice: warm travel-guide / cheerful head-office memo (per `identity.md`). Keep it tight — `complexity-budget.json` caps the rulebook (1650 words). Detail lives in `design-doc.md`. v3 = the vendor-courting engine. You court vendors (not "plate dishes"); two inputs (ingredients + Buzz); each vendor is an engine piece. Fiction labels follow the CD re-skin (rival travel agents building a Taiwan tour); final names → `bg-theme`.

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0. The pitch (read aloud, 20 seconds)

"You're rival travel agents building the best Taiwan food tour. Ride the rails, source real ingredients from the regions that grow them, and drum up Buzz. Spend both to win over the island's vendors — each one you sign makes the next stall easier to court, and pushes you up your Prestige, your Reputation, and how much of the island your tour covers. Chase your own secret signature tour (+7). Best tour is named Top Agent."

1. Goal

Score the most points — from your vendors' Prestige, your Reputation standing, your Region-Coverage breadth, and your secret signature mission (+7, revealed at the end). Most points = Top Agent.

2. Setup (teach while you set up)

1. Unfold the Taiwan map — four regions in a ring: North 北 · Central 中 · South 南 · East 東 (the HSR line links North↔South down the west coast). The board also holds the Season end-timer, the Prestige (score) track, the Reputation track, the tiered Vendor Board (3 rows), and each region's Market slots. Put each agent's Prestige and Reputation markers at 0.
2. Stock each region's Market: its specialty tokens + a couple of Event tiles, shuffled; draw to fill its face-up slots. Set out the pantry pile (convenience store — available anywhere, unlimited) and the Buzz pool.
3. Sort the Vendor deck by tier (Stalls / Eateries / Marquee); shuffle each; deal 3 per tier face-up to the Board (more at higher counts).
4. Each agent: take an Agent Character (one ability + one flaw — read them aloud; they're public) and a pawn (start on opposite regions at 2p — one North, one South). Draw 3 Mission cards, secretly keep 1 (your signature tour, +7); return the other 2 face-down. Your Larder starts empty and stays face-up — your mission is the only thing you keep hidden.

3. How a turn works (the core loop — teach these five, then just play)

On your turn, do ONE action. Then if your Larder (ingredients) is over 7, discard down to 7.

- STOCK UP — take 2 ingredients where you stand (this region's specialties and/or pantry), then refill the Market slots. (A flipped Event tile fires now — see §6.)
- TRAVEL — move to a neighbouring region, then take 1 ingredient there. (North↔South is a neighbour by HSR.)
- PROMOTE — take 2 Buzz (the promotional currency; always available, never contested).
- COURT A VENDOR — the beat that pays. Pick a Board vendor you can afford, pay its cost, and sign it to your tour (§4–§5).
- EXTRACT — file your finished tour / catch the last train home: trigger the end-game (§7).

4. Sourcing & Buzz (the two inputs)

Every vendor wants two things to shine on your tour: - Fresh ingredients — region-specific. You can only take a region's specialty while you're in that region: beef/pork/chicken/egg in the North, tea & pearls in Central, oysters & milkfish in the South, rice & mountain greens in the East. Pantry staples are at the convenience store everywhere. (That's the travel engine: you go where the food lives.) - Buzz — you promote the vendor, promising them customers and hype. That's literally your job as a travel agent: you bring people to the food. Buzz is fungible and safe — one Promote = 2 Buzz.

5. Courting a vendor (the engine)

To court a Board vendor, pay its printed cost: its named ingredients minus your discounts (see below) plus its Buzz (Buzz is never discounted). Take the vendor to your tour and gain, all at once: - its Prestige — move your score marker up now; - its Reputation — move your Rep marker up (milestones give perks — §8); - its perk — usually a permanent region discount icon (see below); higher vendors carry stronger perks (extra Buzz income, a wild, a Rep engine); - a Region-Coverage tick if it's your first vendor in that region. Then refill the Board slot from that tier's deck, advance the Season +1, and — because the vendor has chosen you — your rival is locked out of that vendor.

> The ramp (the "aha"). Each vendor carries a region icon (North/Central/South/East, or a wild). Every matching icon you already hold makes that region's ingredients 1 cheaper on future vendors. Sign a couple of Southern stalls and the next Southern vendor barely needs oysters at all. Buzz is never discounted — so the more you ramp, the more Buzz (not ingredients) becomes the thing that gates your next signing. Sign smart.
>
> Outraced, not robbed. When your rival courts a vendor you wanted, the vendor simply chose them this time — you keep everything you sourced, and there's a fresh stall on the Board. You out-plan each other; you never seize a place.

6. The Market & Events (the island doesn't sit still)

Each region's Market is face-up and finite — there's only so much of each specialty, so grabbing the last oyster forces your rival to reroute. Pantry and Buzz are the two always-available fallbacks, so you're never truly stuck. When you refill the Market, a flipped Event tile fires immediately: - festivals / boons — a mango glut, a bubble-tea festival that hands you Buzz, a kind local who sets you up (most events are good news); - hazards — a typhoon washes out a Market shelf (reroute — you lose nothing you hold), plum rains slow a Stock Up (events tax or delay, never destroy). Boon-skewed, region-thematic, secular. Taking 2 ingredients = up to two flips = a little more risk (that's the push-your-luck, opted into).

7. Ending the trip

The end-game begins the moment either happens: a player takes EXTRACT, or the Season end-timer fills (it advances +1 each time anyone courts a vendor). Then: finish the current round, play one more full round, and stop. (Reaching the top of the Reputation track scores its reward but does not end the game — the Season timer paces the game so the engine has room to build.)

8. Scoring (reveal signature missions now!)

Your markers already show two vectors live. Total four sources: 1. Prestige — the sum of your vendors' stars (already on your score track). 2. Reputation — end-VP by where your Rep marker sits (3→+2

· 6→+4 · 9→+6 · top→+9). (You also collected one-time perks as you passed 3 / 6 / 9.) 3. Region-Coverage — distinct regions your vendors cover: 2→2 · 3→5 · all 4→9. 4. Signature mission — flip it: +7 if you pulled off its vendor pattern, else 0. Add them up. Most points wins → Top Agent. Ties: highest Reputation, then most vendors, then most regions.

9. The warm-tone reminders (margin asides, not rules)

- You're a travel agent promoting Taiwan's food — courting a vendor means winning their blessing by helping them (fresh ingredients + customers), never taking from them or the place.
- Events are the island living its life — festivals, weather, kind locals — never sacred customs played for laughs; local characters are warm, real people, never a punchline.
- Dish/vendor names stay real (Tâi-lô + 繁體). The comedy is the mission gag and your own gluttony — never the food or the place.

Teaching sequence (FTUE — the order a first game should reveal rules)

1. Goal + one Vendor — "here's a beef-noodle stall; it wants 2 North ingredients + 1 Buzz. Let's court it." (Show the two inputs immediately.)
2. Stock Up / Travel / Promote — source the beef (North), take some Buzz; feel the two axes.

3. Court — pay + sign it: Prestige marker moves, Rep marker moves, point at its region icon ("that's your first discount — the next North vendor is cheaper").
4. The ramp — court a second same-region vendor and watch it cost less ingredients (the engine "aha"), and note Buzz still costs full.
5. The Board race — "your rival wants that marquee too; the instant one of you courts it, it's theirs. Outraced, not robbed."
6. Reputation + Coverage — point at the two tracks/vectors; "several ways to win — go tall, climb Rep, or spread across the island."
7. Signature mission — "your secret +7 tour; keep it face-down."
8. Market events — introduce on the first refill flip; "the island lives — this festival just handed you Buzz."
9. Extract / end-game — introduce once the Season is ~half full.

Still to specify (→ `bg-developer`)

- The tiered Vendor deck (~44–52: T1 Stalls / T2 Eateries / T3 Marquee) as component data (CSV): cost (named ingredients + Buzz), region icon, Prestige, Rep, perk.
- The Mission pool (~12–16 vendor patterns, +7; draw-3-keep-1).
- Region Market supplies with ~2–3 Event tiles each; the ~11 Event starter set (design-doc).

- Buzz token supply; add chicken 雞 + egg 蛋 North ingredient tokens; final specialty counts (≈2× solo demand; sub-linear at higher counts).
- Board printing: Season end-timer, Prestige track, Reputation track (milestones 3/6/9/top + perks), Coverage scoring key, the tiered Vendor Board rows + region Market slots.
- 5 Character mats (ability + flaw); keep un-swingy (EV ~2–4 VP), public.
- Player-aid card (≤22 lines) — the five actions + courting cost & discount + the four scoring vectors + end-triggers.
- Iconography for ingredients + 4 regions + the vendor-card layout (dual-coded colour and emblem — `bg-access` / `bg-infodesign`).